

Distilling PROVENCE

The *FOUNDER* of L'Occitane and a visionary *PERFUMER* have looked near and far to produce a *tantalising* new fragrance collection.

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For a beauty editor, a visit to Grasse is a bit like an Elvis fan going to Graceland. L'Occitane en Provence, the French beauty brand, was launching La Collection de Grasse, and had invited me to the perfume capital of the world to meet the creators and learn about traditional distillation methods. For weeks leading up to my trip, I fantasised about fragrant fields of rose and jasmine, waving delicately in a breeze redolent with the scent of spring. Known as the “balcony of the Côte d’Azur”, Grasse boasts a unique microclimate perfect for growing flowers and, in spring, it turns into an olfactory wonderland. In preparation I packed white cotton dresses and K.Jacques sandals and brushed up on my (abysmal) French.

Alas, my *fleur*-drenched fantasy will have to remain just that. A few weeks later, driving through the hills from Nice airport, I see there are no flowers in bloom. Europe has been in the vice-grip of an icy, relentless winter and the plants were still curled beneath the earth, shivering in the morning frosts.

However, tales of fragrant fields do materialise as I embark on a tour of one of the city’s largest flavour and fragrance manufacturers, the Mane Group, which supplies scents to L'Occitane. Many of the world’s finest fragrances are blended in Grasse by companies like Mane, which the big brands engage to manufacture the raw materials and create blends. They use both locally sourced raw materials and essences and extracts imported from overseas, such as vanilla from Madagascar and myrrh from Namibia. It’s this union of ingredients from near and far that inspired L'Occitane’s La Collection de Grasse.

After handing over my passport, I am ushered into Mane’s high-security facility, nestled at the foot of the mountains of Le Bar-Sur-Loup. Men in smart white coats lead me past huge silver vats, explaining the complicated process of steam distillation versus solvent extraction. Today, they are distilling hay (a raw material used to create fragrant blends). The odour is overpowering: dry and earthy, like a freshly baked herb scone but with the kind of intensity that makes you long for fresh air. Usually, at this time of year, the floor would be covered in tiny, fluffy yellow mimosa flowers and the air thick with their sweet, clean smell.

Next stop, the International Perfume Museum, to unveil the fragrances and

meet L'Occitane’s new in-house perfumer Karine Dubreuil. Dubreuil, a warm-eyed, mellifluous-voiced brunette (she also happens to be an opera singer in her downtime) is a Grasse native, or Grassois. She talks me through each of the scents, explaining that each perfume contains one ingredient from near and one from afar. The ampersand on the bottles represents the union of these places.

“When we created this collection, we wanted every woman to find her perfume. So we tried to have one scent from each of the big families,” she explains as I spray each perfume on a card. Indeed, there is something to suit everyone. Each coloured bottle is a scented personality, begging to be tried on. I imagine each of the fragrances as a chic French girl.

Jasmine & Bergamote is unabashedly feminine combined with a splash of Italian audacity. It is a girl who wears a vintage Cacharel floral dress that she found in the

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flea markets, and drinks Aperol spritzers like they’re going out of style.

Vanille & Narcisse is more complex: a warm, non-cloying vanilla contrasted with fresh white narcissus flowers. This girl is mysterious but charming and disarming too. She’s all Vanessa Bruno cashmere and Zadig & Voltaire cigarette pants.

My favourite is Magnolia & Mûre (blackberry), a mouth-watering and musky scent that lingers deliciously on the skin. She’s seductive with a cool edge. The kind of girl who wears Isabel Marant leather jackets and eats Ladurée blackberry macarons in bed.

The final scent in the collection is unisex – Thé Vert & Bigarade (green tea and bitter orange). I conjure up a vision of clean androgyny. She has amazing eyebrows, several pairs of shiny brogues and wears her boyfriend’s cologne.

Back at the hotel, La Bastide Saint-Antoine, it’s Provençal style at its best: a swathe of linen here, a sanded-back armoire there. Rustic simplicity fused with casual grandeur. It’s fitting, then, that this is where I should meet L'Occitane’s

founder, Olivier Bausson. A kind of Pied Piper of Provence, Bausson has a brand that’s brought more attention to the region than any tourism campaign ever could. You can step into any L'Occitane store in Hong Kong, Kazakhstan or Sydney and be instantly swept up in the fragrant emotion of a lavender harvest or elbow deep in a delectable shea butter hand cream.

Bausson, with his gentle voice and rounded eye-glasses, has all the poetic makings of Provençal ambassador. Born and raised in the hills of Haute-Provence, he recalls how his parents were “artist farmers” who defected from Paris to try their hand on the land, growing olives and making goat’s cheese. He recalls sharing his home with a goat called Desdemona.

Later, as a 23-year-old literature student driving his Citroën 2CV through town, he came across an alembic distiller lying neglected in an open shed. “I was struck by the beauty of it. It appeared to me as a kind of magical object,” he says, eyes alight with the memory.

The farmer agreed to sell it to make more room for his car, so Bausson got a trailer and hooked up the hulking metal contraption to his tiny vehicle. Then he drove it to the river where he tried to figure out how to use the damn thing. He eventually mastered the art of distilling rosemary and lavender from the surrounding fields and started making soaps and scents to sell at the local markets. He named his company L'Occitane (pronounced Lox-i-tarne), which means “woman of Occitania” (a medieval province that made up the southern area of France).

The world fell in love with the pure, clean cosmetics, with back-to-basics packaging and a charming French aesthetic. In 1994, Austrian entrepreneur Reinold Geiger joined L'Occitane and helped Bausson take the company to worldwide fame. One of the original eco-chic companies, L'Occitane proudly preserves traditional cultivation methods, growing its own crops of age-defying immortelle flowers in Corsica; supports local producers and communities; and works closely with women’s groups in West Africa’s Burkina Faso, who harvest the shea butter.

Bausson was doing the sustainability thing long before it was trendy. His fierce respect for the land made Provence famous and now he wants to shine a light on Grasse and her many faces. I may not have seen the fields of flowers on this trip, but I did meet the women of Provence. ■